

Step-by-Step Guide for Expats in Dubai

The excitement of relocating to Dubai can quickly turn overwhelming without careful planning. There are several important things every expat needs to consider in order to establish themselves successfully.

Some of these include obtaining visas, finding a place to live, and opening a bank account. The information in this guide has been organised into easy-to-follow steps so that you can maximise your experience in Dubai.

Step One: Get Your Visa

The first step is obtaining a valid residency visa. Most expats in Dubai obtain their visa through one of the following routes:

Employment Visa – The employer typically takes care of most of the process if employed in Dubai.

Investor/Business Visa – If you're going to be working on your own, you'll need to apply through the free zones or government portals.

Freelance Visa – Working as a freelancer is another way to obtain a visa.

Family Sponsored Visa – If you're coming to Dubai to join your spouse, kids or parents, you may come under family sponsorship.

Stage 2: Obtain an Emirates ID

First and foremost, you'll want to get yourself an Emirates ID. This is an essential document that you'll need for most transactions within the United Arab Emirates, so don't forget your ID when trying to rent an apartment or open an account with a bank or get a new cell phone service.

Once your visa has started, you can apply for your Emirates ID, do your biometric enrolment, and receive your Emirates ID card within 5-10 days (depending on how busy that particular processing centre is).

Step 3 - Obtaining a Local SIM Card

Being connected is very important while travelling. In the UAE, two of the largest telecommunications companies are:

Etisalat

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You will be able to purchase a Visitor SIM card and then upgrade to a postpaid plan once you have received your Emirates ID.

Step 4: Finding Where To Live

Dubai has a lot of different kinds of housing for rent, including villas, homes or apartments. Some of the most popular areas of Dubai include: Dubai Marina (a lively and social area), Downtown Dubai (a luxury area in a central location), Jumeirah Village Circle (more affordable housing that is great for families) & Arabian Ranches (family-orientated housing).

Most rental agreements require: A security deposit, 1-4 cheques for payment of the annual rent & an agency fee.

For more information, please verify that you can find what you need in the list of housing options on the Dubai Property Portal and that you are working with an approved agent.

5: Open a Bank Account

An Emirates ID is a necessary requirement to open a bank account. Some popular banks are **Emirates NBD, ADCB and Mashreq Bank**. You need the following documents to open an account with a bank: **copies of your passport, visa, and Emirates ID; plus a salary certificate (if you have a job).**

Step 6: Transportation Setup

Dubai has many transportation options. You can go using the Dubai Metro or take a taxi or ride-hailing app. You could also buy or lease a car in Dubai.

If you're intending to drive in Dubai, regardless of your nationality, you may need to convert your driver's licence from your home country or take driving lessons to obtain a new driver's licence.

Step 7: Health Insurance

There is a requirement for people living in Dubai to have compulsory medical insurance. Your employer will typically provide you with coverage, while your employer must provide you with your medical insurance if you are self-employed. You would need to verify with your health insurance provider to ensure that you can access both local hospitals and clinics.

Step 8: Schooling (If You Have Kids)

The many types of international schools offering British, IB, American and Indian curricula in Dubai give parents plenty of choices.

Areas where most schools can typically be found include:

1. Al Barsha
2. Mirdif
3. Dubai Hills Estate

With competitive admission to many of these schools, it's important to apply early!

Step 9: Understand Cost of Living

Living in Dubai means your income is tax-free; however, your living expenses will vary considerably because they depend on your lifestyle. Your most significant expenses will consist of:

1. Rent
2. Utilities (DEWA, air conditioning)
3. Food
4. Transportation
5. School Fees

Those who budget early typically do not experience unexpected expenses when moving to Dubai.

Step 10: Settle Into the Lifestyle

Living in Dubai means immersing yourself in many different cultures, and life in Dubai can move rapidly with a very high standard of living. You must show respect for local laws, customs, and dress codes, especially when visiting parts of the city that require modest dress. Do not cause public disturbance or behave inappropriately; however, do enjoy the many things Dubai has to offer, including beaches, restaurants, networking opportunities, and many other possibilities!

Final Thoughts

Dubai is one of the easiest cities in the world to relocate to—if you follow the right steps.

Focus on:

1. Legal setup (visa + Emirates ID)
2. Essentials (bank, SIM, housing)
3. Lifestyle adjustments

Once these are sorted, you'll find Dubai extremely rewarding—whether you're here to grow your career, invest, or build a new life.